

IV

A PRACTICE GUIDE FROM THE HUSH ROOM

Centering Prayer.

Contemplative Prayer · Opening the will to God.



Twenty minutes of silence. A single sacred word. Not emptying the mind — but consenting, with everything in you, to the presence of God already there.

"Be still, and know that I am God."

Psalm 46:10

THE PRACTICE

What centering prayer is.

Most prayer involves words. We speak to God; God, we hope, speaks back. Centering Prayer is different. It is the prayer of silent consent. We sit. We breathe. We let go of the thoughts that come, and we open ourselves to a Presence that has always been there, beneath the noise.

The practice is ancient. The fourth-century Desert Fathers prayed this way. The unknown 14th-century author of *The Cloud of Unknowing* taught it. In the 1970s, three Cistercian monks — Thomas Keating, Basil Pennington, William Meninger — recovered the practice for the modern church and gave it the name we use today: Centering Prayer.

It is a method of silent prayer that prepares us to receive the gift of God's presence.

Notice the careful framing. Centering Prayer does not produce God's presence. It does not summon Him. It simply prepares us — quiets us — so that we are receptive when He offers Himself, as He always does, to those who turn toward Him.

And after the wind an earthquake; but the LORD was not in the earthquake. And after the earthquake a fire; but the LORD was not in the fire. And after the fire a still small voice.

1 Kings 19:11–12

Elijah stood at the mouth of the cave. The wind came. Then the earthquake. Then the fire. God was in none of them. He was in the silence — what older translations called a sound of sheer silence, a still small voice. Centering Prayer is a way of learning to wait, in the silence, until He speaks.

THE FOUR GUIDELINES

Thomas Keating's pattern, in plain language.

Twenty minutes is the traditional length. Most practitioners pray twice daily. Begin with one session. Begin with ten minutes if twenty feels too long. The practice has only four steps.

i. Choose

Choose a sacred word.

Pick a single word — short, simple, prayerful. Jesus. Father. Abba. Mercy. Love. Peace. Yes. Open. Lord. The word is not magical. It is a symbol — a small token of your consent to God's presence and action within you.

Don't change the word once you've chosen it. Don't analyse it. It is your anchor for the practice.

ii. Sit

Sit, eyes closed. Introduce the word.

Find a comfortable position — feet flat, hands resting, spine soft but not slumped. Close your eyes. Take a few breaths.

Then, gently, introduce your sacred word. Say it once, silently, in your mind. That is all. You have begun.

iii. Return

When thoughts come, return.

Thoughts will come. Plans, memories, feelings, replays of conversations. This is not failure. The thoughts are not the enemy. The practice is simply this: when you notice you are engaged with a thought, gently return to your sacred word.

Don't fight the thought. Don't analyse it. Don't berate yourself for having it. Just — like a hand returning to a touchstone — come back to the word. This may happen a hundred times in twenty minutes. Each return is the prayer.

iv. End

Close with the Lord's Prayer.

When the time is up, do not jump up. Sit for two minutes in silence — let the prayer settle. Then close by silently or softly praying the Lord's Prayer.

Open your eyes slowly. Stand slowly. Carry the silence with you into the rest of the day.

WHAT THIS IS, AND IS NOT

A few honest clarifications.

Centering Prayer is not Eastern meditation. It is not emptying the mind. It is not seeking visions or experiences or special feelings. It is not a technique to lower blood pressure (though it may). It is not Bible study, intercession, or worship — all of which are good and necessary, but different.

Centering Prayer is the prayer of presence. It is sitting with God, in silence, with your will open. Most days, you will feel nothing dramatic. The fruit is not in the session. The fruit is in the rest of your life — a slow softening, a deeper patience, a less reactive heart.

A note: Be patient with yourself. The first weeks of Centering Prayer often feel like nothing — or worse, like restlessness, distraction, and self-criticism. This is normal. The practice is a long obedience in the same direction. Give it three months before you decide whether it is bearing fruit.

A blessing as you begin.

May you discover that the silence is not empty.

*May you learn to wait without straining,
to listen without rehearsing,
to be loved without earning.*

*And in that waiting,
may you be found.*

The Father waits. The Son welcomes. The Spirit moves.